

Recently and lately

[Learner workbook](#)

Choose a tense that fits the event, not just the adverb.

Understand the distinction

Recently means a short time ago or during the recent past. It can describe one finished event with the past simple: I recently bought a bike. It also occurs with the present perfect: I have recently changed jobs.

Lately usually describes recent states or repeated activity, often with the present perfect: I have been busy lately; I have been cycling lately. It is less usual for a single finished event. Neither word requires the present perfect continuous, and neither guarantees that an activity will continue.

Compare the patterns

ONE EVENT

I recently visited a friend.

Past simple fits a finished visit.

RECENT STATE

I have been tired lately.

Been + adjective describes a state.

REPEATED ACTIVITY

I have been walking more lately.

The continuous form highlights activity.

Read each example. Explain what the highlighted choice means in context. Then cover the example and say a similar sentence.

Check your understanding

Write before looking at the answers. The guide gives a model answer and explains the choice. Other wording can be correct.

1. Choose for a single visit: I visited Rome ____ . (recently / lately)

2. Is I have been busy lately a present perfect continuous verb?

3. Does I have been running lately guarantee future running?

Use it in your own life

Write one recent event and one recent habit or state.

Self-check

Does your sentence express your intended meaning? Does its form follow the relevant pattern? Can a reader understand the context?

Try again

After checking the explanation, revise your sentence. Say it aloud or use it in a short conversation.

Answers and explanation

1. recently

Recently readily refers to a single past event.

2. No. It is present perfect be followed by an adjective.

The continuous form needs an -ing main verb.

3. No. It describes recent activity.

Future continuation needs more context.

One possible response

I recently joined a class. I have been studying more lately.

This is a model, not the only acceptable answer. Assess meaning, grammar, and context together.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-16.html